

# The Masque of the Red Death

“The Masque of the Red Death” is a short story by Edgar Allan Poe, first published in 1842. A landmark work of Gothic fiction and allegory, it follows Prince Prospero’s attempt to shut out a deadly plague, only to reveal the impossibility of escaping mortality.

## Key facts

- **Author:** Edgar Allan Poe
- **First publication:** May 1842 (in *Graham’s Magazine*)
- **Genre:** Gothic fiction, allegorical horror
- **Setting:** Prince Prospero’s castellated abbey during a plague
- **Narrative style:** Third-person, symbolic and atmospheric

## Plot and structure

As a devastating pestilence known as the Red Death ravages the land, Prince Prospero gathers a thousand nobles inside his fortified abbey and stages a lavish masked ball. The revelry moves through a suite of vividly colored rooms, ending in a black chamber lit by a scarlet glow. At midnight, an uninvited masked figure appears, seeming to embody the Red Death itself. When Prospero confronts it, he dies, and the guests discover there is no human presence beneath the costume.

## Themes and interpretation

The story is widely read as an allegory of death’s inevitability and the futility of privilege in the face of human mortality. Poe contrasts wealth, spectacle, and denial with the unstoppable force of time and decay. The colored rooms, the ominous clock, and the final intruder all reinforce a movement toward judgment and extinction.

## Style and influence

One of Poe’s most visually and symbolically rich tales, “The Masque of the Red Death” blends ornate description with compressed narrative force. Its imagery and structure have influenced generations of Gothic, horror, and fantasy writers, and the story remains one of Poe’s most anthologized works.